white, but any attempt to do so would oversimplify matters. Based on their historical experience with the 2010 elections (and for Kachin State, also the 2012 by-elections), most stakeholders had no trust in the election administration. The upcoming elections were also not a priority for most armed groups and their constituents. Their attention was on fighting, advancing the ongoing peace negotiations toward the NCA, maintaining the bilateral ceasefires, and profiting from them through increased access to local markets and services. For many EAGs, their continued non-acceptance of the 2008 Constitution also contradicted an intensified interest in elections, even if an earlier change of their legal status would have allowed increased engagement. Some alleged that EAGs denied political parties access to their territories, however, many said they would not disrupt the electoral process even prior to the NCA. It is in this context that elections were partially cancelled.

The partial cancellation of elections

The 2015 elections did not take place in all parts of the country. Elections were cancelled (postponed) in seven townships and partially in some townships in 416 additional wards or village tracts[6] in conflict-affected areas, as announced by the UEC in two rounds, on 12 and 27 October 2015.[7] The number of excluded voters did probably not exceed half a million (see TNI 2015, p. 5), or roughly 1.5 per cent of the population registered to vote. The October notifications were largely expected by observers and followed a similar pattern of announcements ahead of the 2010 elections. Nevertheless, the cancellations are one of the least understood and least transparent elements of the Myanmar elections.

The authority to cancel and postpone elections lies with the UEC, and ultimately with its chairman; however, the decision-making process is informed from below. Administrative personnel with electoral duties at ward and village tract level inform township and district subcommissions. The state/region subcommissions then provide the recommendation to postpone elections, if needed, to their superiors in Naypyitaw. While the internal administration of this process appears to involve several levels, the decision-making for cancellations is little understood outside the involved apparatus. There were some negotiations around whether to hold elections under the condition of volatile ceasefires — for example in Kayin State's Kyainseikgyi township or in northern Shan State's Mongmit township —